

INTRODUCTION TO LITERARY CRITICISM

PRE-THINK-IT

- ✖ Consider your thematic interpretative claims from last week
- ✖ How difficult was it to come up with them?
- ✖ What was difficult about it?
- ✖ How could you focus your approach to make it easier?

LITERARY CRITICISM

- ✘ “Literary criticism” is the name given to works written by experts who critique—analyze—an author’s work.
- ✘ It does NOT mean “to criticize” as in complain or disapprove.
- ✘ Remember, literary criticism is used by readers to analyze, NOT by authors to write.
- ✘ One way to access the foundation of literary criticism (i.e. “Theme”) is through the viewpoints of critics that have come before us.

LITERARY CRITICISM AND THEORY

- ✗ Any piece of text can be read with a number of different sets of “glasses,” meaning you are looking for different things within the text.
- ✗ Literary criticism through critical lenses helps readers understand a text in relation to the author, culture, and other texts.



THE MOST COMMON CRITICAL STANCES FOR LITERATURE

- ✗ Formalistic
- ✗ Gender
- ✗ Historical/Cultural
- ✗ Psychological
- ✗ Marxist



INTRODUCTION TO LITERARY THEORY, FEMINIST AND GENDER CRITICISM

PRE-THINK-IT

- ✗ Read the short poem “Girl”
- ✗ On a sheet of paper, or your computer come up with your own version, but this time for “Boy” –demonstrate male stereotypes and guidelines for behavior. This is an assignment on Teams.

WHAT ARE THE GENDER STEREOTYPES?

- ✗ “Girl” and your “Boy” poem should have brought to mind a multitude of stereotypes and expectations, add them to this padlet:



<https://bit.ly/3BcCY0j>

WHAT DO WE MEAN WHEN WE SAY “FEMINIST CRITICISM”?

- ✗ The phrase “Feminist Criticism” is an umbrella term for several varieties of critical analysis and interpretation of literature that use as a base some of the assumptions of the feminist movement.
- ✗ Several other *distinct* types of criticism have branched off from Feminist Criticism. Queer Theory and Gender Studies both grew out of ideas originally developed by feminist critics.
- ✗ Feminist Criticism and related theories are unapologetically political. Critics who use these theories share the strong belief that examining literature through the lens of Feminist Criticism can be a tool for social and political awareness and for change.

IMPORTANT TERMS FOR GENDER AND FEMINIST CRITICISM

- ✘ Patriarchy: a system of beliefs and social practices that supports male dominance by denying women access to power, privileging issues/voices that are seen as “masculine” over those that are “feminine,” and exerting control over women’s bodies and sexualities.
- ✘ Gender: A socially constructed set of expectations for what is “masculine” and what is “feminine.” (As opposed to “sex,” which is biological.)

IMPORTANT TERMS FOR GENDER AND FEMINIST CRITICISM

- ✗ Agency – The capacity for a person to act or make decisions independently in the world
 - + If you do not have the power to speak up for yourself you do not have agency, or the capacity to act for your own benefit
- ✗ Hegemony – leadership, predominance
 - + A hegemony is a dominant group or system that creates the societal rules we live by.

FEMINIST CRITICAL QUESTIONS

1. To what extent does the representation of women (and men) in the work reflect the time and place in which the work was written? To what extent does this portrayal *value* those concerns?
2. How are the relationships between men and women presented in the work?
3. Does the author present the work from within a predominantly male or female perspective?

FEMINIST CRITICAL QUESTIONS

4. In what ways is *patriarchy* present in a particular work? How are the effects of patriarchy evident in the lives and attitudes of the characters?
5. Do female characters show signs of resistance to patriarchy? If so, how is this resistance portrayed?
6. How do the facts of the author's life relate to the presentation of men and women in the work?

A (NOT SO) BRIEF NOTE ON THE "LITERARY CANON"

- ✗ Definition of "Canon:" Originally, the term "canon" applied to the books of the Bible that were accepted as "divinely inspired." (The word "canon" comes from a Greek word meaning "rule" or "measure.") Therefore, the group of books that was accepted at any given time was referred to as the "canon of scripture," and books *outside* of that canon were referred to as "non-canonical."

A (NOT SO) BRIEF NOTE ON THE "LITERARY CANON" (CONT.)

The idea of the "Literary Canon" says that over time, teachers, academics, writers, and public opinion have, consciously or unconsciously, *chosen* works that are considered "worthy" of study. This *also* means that there must be *other* works that are *not* "worthy" of study. (Please note that there was never an actual *list* of works in the literary canon, and works have risen and fallen in status over time.)

For much of history, the "literary canon" in Western literature (used broadly to mean literature of places that have their foundation in Greek and Latin cultures... meaning Europe and most of the Americas post-Columbus) has been written by white men.

SO WHAT DOES THE HISTORY OF THE “LITERARY CANON” MEAN FOR FEMINIST CRITICS?

- ✗ Feminist Critics are often interested in literary representations of women, and in bringing attention to works by women that have historically been overlooked.
- ✗ Feminist Critics believe that for much of history, the "literary canon" and the field of literary criticism have both been dominated by men, and they seek to expose the effects of this patriarchal mindset.
- ✗ By looking at the ways that women's concerns and women's writing has been marginalized, they seek to address the *imbalance* that has traditionally persisted in favor of men's writing and men's concerns.

GENDER AND FEMINIST CRITICISM

- ✘ Many Gender Critics see a difference between *gender* (which is socially constructed) and sex (which is biological).
- ✘ This means that ideas about "typically" masculine or feminine traits and behaviors are products of culture and social conditioning.
- ✘ Gender Critics are interested in how works of literature either *support* or *undermine* the "standards" of masculine/feminine behavior and identity held by the culture in which they were produced.

WATCH “LISA VS. MALIBU STACY”

- ✘ Note five examples of the “patriarchy” or “patriarchal hegemony” at work in the show.
- ✘ Note three examples of a female character with “agency.”
- ✘ Note three examples of a female character relinquishing her “agency.”
- ✘ Write a personal response to the episode.
- ✘ At least a page in length (typed, double-spaced MLA)

QUESTIONS FOR “STORY OF AN HOUR”

Write a response to “Story of an Hour” utilizing the questions below as a guide.

- ✕ Using evidence from the text, describe the Mallard marriage.
- ✕ What is the irony of this story?
- ✕ Do you think that this story is critical of marriage *as an institution*? Why or why not?
- ✕ What can the critical lens of feminist/gender criticism help us to make of this story? (How does it either support or undermine gender roles? In what ways does it comment on women’s issues?)
At least one half page (typed, double-spaced MLA).

BODY PARAGRAPH FOR “STORY OF AN HOUR”

- ✗ Using evidence from the text (quotes) write a body paragraph for a gender analysis of “Story of an Hour”
- ✗ Include:
 - + A topic sentence (what aspect of the story are you focusing on?)
 - + Embedded Quotes from the text (with citation) (at least two)
 - + Explanation of how those quotes fit your gender interpretation (at least two)
 - + A concluding sentence about the topic